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REVOLUTION

By Steve DuBois

[ARNOLD kneels at stage center, clad in a tattered wool overcoat, well-worn leather boots, and a cloth cap; his hands are wrapped in rags to ward off the cold. Beside him is a flintlock musket and a large canvas pack, the contents of which—salt pork, a jar of flour, a canteen, minie balls and gunpowder cartridges, flint and tinder, change of clothes—are scattered around him. As the lights come up, he glances up in surprise.]

Well! This is…different.

You'll excuse my disheveled appearance, I hope. Not what one would expect of a prosperous New Haven trader, let alone a general of the colonial army. Nor is a snowbound wilderness trail an ideal location to receive guests. But then, I seldom have visitors. It's been a long while—centuries, in fact--since anyone has cared to keep company with the likes of me.

It was different once. Once, they called me a hero of the revolution.

Heh…"Revolution". Take a long look at that word; a good general examines the ground before entering into battle. The enemy has set a trap for you--do you see it? You're taught to think of revolutions in terms of progress, in terms of steady movement forwards. Ah, but…

[He traces a circle in the air]

…*revolution*. The movement isn't progressive, it's *circular*. It *revolves*. Like the wheel of a cart or the head of a screw. Destiny's coin, flipping in midair. Turning, turning. The wheel turns, but in the end, it always comes back to the same place.

[Intro here.]

It's freezing out here. Let's see if I can at least get a fire going.

[As he speaks, he limps around his camp, gathering materials together and attempting to start a fire. He is active and energetic, almost to the point of being spastic at times, though he winces every time he puts weight on his left leg.]

All the contents of my soldier's pack, scattered here in the snow. Not my nature to be so disorganized. Whatever you think of me, know I did nothing without a reason. The revolution—well, no man can say we weren't provoked. Imagine it: to sail your vessel to the West Indies with a cargo purchased on credit, never seeing your Peggy or your sons for months at a time, with your entire fortune bound up in the hold, knowing that the slightest mishap would reduce your family to destitution. To slip safely into port: you've done it. Your skills and your nerve have been the making of you. The profits await.

And there stands the man, in his finery, with a smirk on his face, and a stamp in his hand. This man waits to assess the value of your goods, and to take the tenth part of it for himself, and for his King.

Sibi totique, that was my motto in trade. "For myself and for all." For all--of course! I was ever-eager to serve! But there's a *contract* in it, do you see? An equal exchange! This man

with the stamp, with his smooth, uncallused hands—what has he risked? Was it any wonder that we rose in revolution?

And was it any wonder that I was in the vanguard? Oh, don't think I don't know what you've made of your legendary "founding fathers". That's my fate, you see. To know everything that occurs in the nation I midwived into existence. Franklin, the icon of enlightenment and reason. Washington, the living god. Hamilton, the… rap musician? I can't make heads or tails of that one.

But while they were bickering and jabbering in Philadelphia, I took action. In the fall of '75, I embarked on my most ambitious enterprise. A midwinter invasion of Canada! The sheer audacity of it! And it almost worked! If it hadn't been for a freak storm, we would have beaten the British forces to the capital of Quebec. The whole continent in American hands! The flip of history's coin. How different things might have been.

Instead—trapped outside the walls. Smallpox running rampant, no provisions or hope of reinforcement. Shot twice through the leg and sent packing back to the south, fighting off the British at every turn. Blood in the snow—my own, and that of my brave boys. A month earlier Congress had called me the "American Hannibal"; now, they condemned me as a "glory-hunter."

And then came the letter from home. Peggy, whom I'd abandoned on all those trading voyages. Peggy, whom I'd left behind as I marched off in search of liberty and glory. She was gone. A sudden fever. My sons, motherless.

So be it. *Sibi totique*. In war, we must all endure losses. My sons I left in the care of my sister. I accepted Congress' scorn, accepted their assignment as a subordinate to that flatulent, indolent imbecile, Gates, at Saratoga. And while he sat in his tent, talking politics with a captured British officer, we broke the British lines! Charging the redoubts on horseback, at the head of my troops, straight forward into the cannonfire! A British officer would later say that there "seemed to shoot out from me a magnetic flame that electrified my men and made heroes of all within the sphere of my influence."

Truth was, I was blasted out of my mind on rum. We all were. Somebody brought a barrel into camp…but no matter! We crushed them utterly and brought the French into the war on the side of the Colonies. We won the war that day! Every ounce of the liberty you enjoy, you owe to me, and to those brave boys! Those brave, drunk boys!

But I never saw the victory. A volley of musket fire brought down my horse—right on top of this same damned leg, can you believe it? Shattered it, like ice under a hammer. Those butchers in the medical tent left it two inches shorter than the other. Every step, forevermore, a jolt of agony. Every stride a new, fresh hell.

I wrote to Congress. My neglected business was a ruin, my debts astronomical. My sister and my sons shivered in a stripped house, unable to afford so much as a cord of firewood! And those worms in Philadelphia would not authorize a cent to reimburse me! They said my charge —the charge that won America's liberty--had been "unauthorized"! Instead they awarded a gold medal to General Gates, "the hero of Saratoga."

What would you do? I had sacrificed everything! My fortune! My family! My goddamned LEG, for Christ's sake! I had made myself a cripple in the service of my country! And yet I had been undermined at every turn by men who never lifted a musket, by those schemers and speechifiers, those slave-holding "champions of liberty"!

Sibi totique! For others, AND for myself! I had spent too much time at the bottom of the wheel, being ground beneath it. It was time for things to turn!

So…yes. Yes, I did it. I…changed sides. I sold the British the plans for the defense of West Point.

I sold them all. All those boys, who bled and died at my command—I sold their sacrifice. All the men who'd praised my courage, and defended my honor in the corridors of power—Schuyler, Washington--I sold their faith in me, and made them look like fools. My honor, the respect of my countrymen, my eternal reputation—I sold it all. From trader, to soldier, to trader again—round and round goes the wheel.

I provided for my family. I turned my back on all I had loved. I went into exile and into infamy. And I went to my deathbed expecting hell. Instead…

[Arnold gestures broadly at his surroundings.]

...I woke up here.

And perhaps this *is* hell. Because every morning I wake up on this trail, in the freezing cold, and I hoist my burden, and I limp onwards. Just as my boys did in the winter of '75. I am fated to know all that occurs in the nation I left behind. But of my own ultimate destination I have no idea. I know only that my march will continue, day after day, century after century, so long as America endures. Every morning, I will awaken on this trail, to find the wheel has come around to the same place again. A never-ending revolution. An eternal reminder that no man may escape the circle of his own character.

I deserve this. I don't deny it. But it's not *all* I deserve.

You'll tell them, won't you? Take my story back with you. The *whole* story. I was a traitor, yes. But that's not *all* I was.

A pleasant diversion, this. And now, if you'll excuse me…

[Arnold shrugs the pack onto his shoulders, then turns his back.]

…I have a long walk ahead.

[He limps away.]